

states UTTAR PRADESH

the end of Dadua's reign of terror is a breather both for the traumatised villagers of Bundelkhand and for the political parties who had connived with him to promote their own ends.

To the people of Chitrakoot-Banda, Dadua was an embodiment of cruelty. He killed those he suspected of being police informants; didn't hesitate to loot the poorest of farmers or rape minor girls. A year ago, informant Munni Lal and his son Harish Chandra of Gurdari Mau village in Chitrakoot district were first shot at and then soaked in diesel before being set afire by Dadua and his gang.

Dozens of horrified villagers were witness, yet none approached the police for fear of meeting a similar fate. Police in Manikpur, a part of Chitrakoot district, believe Dadua killed at least 50 informers, in a similar medieval manner. Villages were reduced to being the 'subjects' of "Dadua Sarkar". In some villages, says Mohandas Mishra, pradhan of Gurdari village, men would leave their homes at night, with their womenfolk staying behind, "so that Dadua and his gang could do as they pleased".

Dadua's stomping ground, arid and rocky Bundelkhand is, in any case, an agricultural wasteland and has not seen any industrial growth for decades. Economic migration is higher than the national average here and only the most hopeless and vulnerable stay behind. For close to three decades, it was these poorest of the poor who were Dadua's victims. Not even the state came to their aid.

Instead, political parties of all stripes—Communists, the Congress, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), the Samajwadi Party (SP)—were quick to exploit Dadua, realising the grip of vice he had over villagers. Former BJP MP Prakash Narain Tripathi faced a charge of giving shelter to the bandit, an accusation also made against Ram Sajivan. Sajivan has won two Lok Sabha elections from this region on Communist Party of India and then BSP tickets.

Before the assembly elections in 2002, Dadua's men had their own slogan, "*Mohar lagegi haathi per, nahi goli padegi chaati per* (vote for the elephant, the BSP symbol, or get a bullet in the chest)". But after the elections, he

switched loyalties to the ruling SP, led by Mulayam Singh Yadav. The police remained soft on Dadua and he, in turn, supported SP. Dadua's brother Bal Kumar contested assembly election on an SP ticket from Patti in Rae Bareilly, while his son Bir Singh won the Zila Panchayat elections unopposed. At a function in 2005, SP MP Shyama Charan Gupta publicly announced that he was grateful to the Dadua family and would pay them back for their support. Mishra says, "More than a dozen gram pradhans have been elected unopposed on Dadua's support."

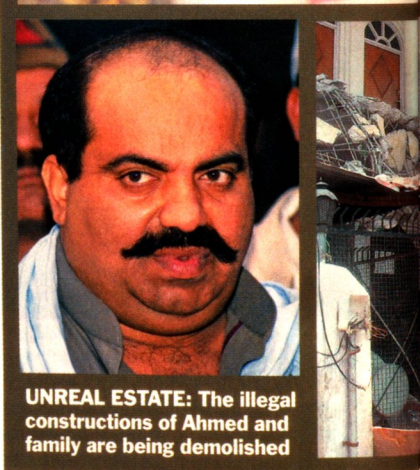
For decades, Dadua remained untouched and untroubled in the forests of the Vindhyas because of the brazen political support and shelter given to him by all political parties. STF Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Amitabh Yash, who led the operation that led to Dadua's end, told INDIA TODAY: "Dadua had distorted the democratic and political system and the state machinery."

When Mayawati returned to power, it was her best chance to wipe the slate clean of her party's association with Dadua. She was willing to go after both hardcore criminals as well as the criminals in politics. Shailja Kant Mishra, who along with another senior IPS officer Vinod Kumar Singh led anti-mafia operations in 1991 in the Kalyan Singh government, was appointed additional director general in the STF.

Yash was then named SSP of the force despite his earlier run-in with Mayawati. In 2003, Yash had named the then minister Amarmani Tripathi for the killing of poetess Madhumita Shukla in his report and was suspended by Mayawati. This time though, Yash was given greater responsibility. During his posting in Jalaun two years ago, he had almost liquidated the Nirbhay Gujjar gang and returned to the STF with his reputation enhanced.

Yet though Dadua has been taken out today, Mayawati knows that she has to keep cracking the whip on those colloquially referred to in Uttar Pradesh as the *dadoos*, meaning "the powerful" or the criminal element among the political classes.

The political patronage enjoyed by



UNREAL ESTATE: The illegal constructions of Ahmed and family are being demolished

Dadua is only a reflection of the criminalisation of politics in Uttar Pradesh. Mafia don-turned-MIA Mukhtar Ansari, lodged in Ghazipur jail, enjoyed the luxury of having a pond dug inside the jail where fish were bred. Why? So that he and his cohorts could enjoy fresh fish in their meals, shared occasionally with a high-profile cabinet minister.

Ansari held daily 'darbar' in the jail where a small piece of land was reserved to grow another of his culinary favourites, basmati rice. Most of the